

Like always, the Consumer Electronics Show this year had a whole plethora of products; some were impressive and some were absolutely jaw-dropping. Well some were weird but we'll get to them later. The two noticeable trends were 'small is beautiful' and 'low-cost'; the latter being quite in line with the general economic climate. The flashy larger-than-life stuff was

there but a fair bit of emphasis was on consumer models than prototypes. We saw the lines between Netbook, Notebook and Ultra-portable blurring and hi-end camera's becoming unimaginably small. Now that the dust has settled its time for us to sieve through the chaff and give you a round up of things that caught out attention.



Enter

ULTRA PORTABLE NETBOOK

Sony Vaio P

It's not a Netbook — and don't you forget it. Sony calls their nifty little device a Pocket Style PC. It's an ultra thin, 594 grams fully functional PC. It was one of the hottest item numbers in Vegas and we got our hand on one when we were invited for its India

can really use the keyboard comfortably. But Sony has engaged in some good re-engineering there; they've got rid of the touch pad and put in a ThinkPad style 'dot' to operate the cursor. The additional space created is engulfed by the keyboard, making it 92 per cent of a full size notebook keyboard. Numbers aside, it's very easy to use with both hands (unless of course you've got



Launch. The India product head for Vaio pulled a familiar stunt by pulling out the device from his jacket pocket. But believe us this is no stunt — it can comfortably slip into a coat pocket. The device is as small as a PC can get without compromising on usability. Its got a 8-inch ultra wide screen with a stunning 1600 x 768 display, and 2 gigs RAM which is more than enough to allow the preinstalled Vista OS to not choke. Initially because of its small size we were sceptical about whether one

sumo fingers) and the tactile feedback is good.

Why is the Netbook tag blasphemy? Sony says this is because theirs is a fully functional PC with no compromises like other Netbooks. We say it's because of the price. The two variants to be available in India will be priced around Rs. 49,990 and Rs. 64,990. The difference in both models is in the processor and the Version of Vista. The higher variant (P15) is based on the Atom Z530 1.6 GHz processor, while the lower P13 has a

Z520 1.33 GHz processor.

The P has a lot of little features added to make it even more easy to use than it already is. If boot time is a concern it launched into a Linux based Cross Media Bar within 20 seconds, which lets you access mostly everything you want including internet access, email, music, and photos. Then there is the Window arrangement utility button which quickly arranges all open windows side by side. Plus the wide screen actually lets you comfortably work on both windows. So no more alt-tabbing. Sony has also thrown in noise cancelling in-earphones and apparently the noise cancelling circuitry is in the Netbook... err... notebook itself. With a supposed battery life of 3 hours it's something that a lot of people ought to be looking forward to in 2009.

IPHONE KILLER?

Palm Pre

Perhaps the first real iPhone killer, the Palm Pre is being talked about as the hottest product of CES 2009. Its small, light, has an intuitive touch screen, but best of all its got a neatly tucked in sliding full qwerty keyboard! The lack of a keyboard is the most common complaint of

iPhone critics. The phone comes with a 3.1 inch multitouch display with a resolution of 320 x 480. It runs on Palm's new webOS, which from a usability standpoint appears to be top-notch. Its not at all sluggish and seamlessly floats from one ap (or 'card' as they call it) to another. Still it remains somewhat of a mystery as reportedly the palm representatives were quite cagey about handing over the phone to people for too long. Understandable, since the phone is Palm's ticket for a big comeback, after their sales plummeted drastically over the years. Overall the phone looks pretty good and the slight bend the keyboard offers will definitely help in its basic function — talking. Another area where it scores over the iPhone is the camera. Its got a 3 megapixel camera with LED flash. The touch screen has its own motion-specific commands. For instance to close an application just flick it upwards. What about independent aps? As of now there aren't any but the webOS allows development in Javascript, HTML and CSS. Other tid-bits include incredible web integration with services such as Facebook and Microsoft exchange. It follows a unique form of collecting info like mail, messages, chats, around a

Security Watch

Downadup worm wrecking havoc

A worm by the name of Win32.Worm.Downadup.B. is fast spreading across the net. Within four days, it infected four times the numbers of computers it was on. The rapid spread is because the worm skirts around AV software by using rarely-used APIs in the system. The worm hides in a folder in the recycle bin, and updates itself by checking upto 250 randomly generated domain names, which have components.

The safest way to prevent the spread of this particular worm is to not switch USB drives between computers. If your USB drive has a mysterious recycle bin folder, there is a good chance that you have this worm. Keep your work USB drives separate from the ones for personal use to prevent either your workplace or your home computer from being infected.

Microsoft has released a patch, but the fix itself was faulty.

The worm affects XP, Windows 2000 and Windows Server 2003. There are no workarounds as yet. The worm is spreading by exploiting multiple systemic weaknesses, including weak passwords. The worm restricts some traffic (like system updates), but is otherwise not involved in any malicious activity. The main threat at this point of time is the worm allowing computers to be used by a botnet. These can be used to send spam for example. Downadup is also known as Conficker and Kido.



'person' than a service. Currently the Pre is not available in GSM version but Palm is expected to announce a GSM/UMTS model for Europe and Asia in mid-February. We're certainly eagerly awaiting it.

THE CLONE

MSI X320

Why this particular notebook? Because it's the MacBook Air's twin. And a not so pricey twin at that. While the Macbook air will set you back by \$1600 this ultra thin notebook's price range is from \$800-\$1,000. Still, there is more to this ultra-thin notebook than just the price. It's not a cheap knockoff. The X320, like the Air, has an all-aluminium body. It weighs, in-fact, a little less than the Air; its LED screen is not different from the Mac Air, with a screen resolution of 1,366x768 and a 16:9 form factor. Where it differs is in the keyboard and touch pad. The keyboard does not follow the isolated style of the Air and of course there are no gesture capabilities on the touch-pad such as pinching and three finger swiping etc. Yet, some of the X320's features can actually make the Air squirm. For instance a total of three USB ports. VGA and

Ethernet ports are built in, and so are the SD slot and webcam. The hard drive is 160 GB but expandable to 250 GB. There's no internal 3G wireless, but Bluetooth and Wi-Fi are present. MSI claims the four cell battery will give you 10 hours of battery life, which will have to be put to test. But fact remains this is the closest thing to a Mac without it really being a Mac.

THE STUDIO NOTEBOOK

DELL XPS 16

Dell has positioned this notebook as a very high end lifestyle product, for the discerning consumer who wants style, power and a little bit of prestige that comes along with owning a pc like this. Many manufacturers are currently offering near desktop configs in portable laptops, be it 4gigs of RAM, home-theater features, and big screens. But dell has upped the ante with its stunning design and inbuilt technology, while of course keeping up with all other specs. Take the screen for instance; a 16 inch RGB LED widescreen with a 1080p resolution — perhaps a graphics professionals dream. Its bundled with a blue ray reader and an HDMI port. The XPS 16 doesn't

come cheap; you'll have to shell out Rs. 90k to own this bad boy. Good bang for the buck.

THERE WERE OTHER PHONES TOO YOU KNOW

Mobinnova Ice Phone

Though most of the action was going on at the Palm Pre booth, another interesting handset found on the show floor was the Mobinnova Ice. It looks quite funky with a complete black body with no visible buttons when it's off. So in effect it looks like a big black shiny box until you start operating it. Everything on the front is touch-sensitive and only lights up as needed. Its got a 3 inch 240x400 touch screen, and the control buttons next to the main screen. The phone gives a vibration feedback when you touch buttons, so you know what you've touched. It runs Windows Mobile 6.1 Professional on a 528 MHz Qualcomm 7201A processor and has your standard 3G, GPS, Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, a 3-megapixel camera, TV out, an FM radio and an accelerometer.

THE TABLET NETBOOK

ASUS EEE T101H and EEE T91

ASUS, who probably started the whole Netbook craze with its EEE PC, is nowhere close to being overrun by competitors in the fray. To prove this point it introduced its newest